

PAKISTANI EMBROIDERY

is the handicraft of decorating fabric or other materials with needle and thread or yarn. Embroidery may also incorporate other materials such as metal strips, pearls, beads, quills, and sequins. Embroidery is most often used on caps, hats, coats, blankets, dress shirts, denim, stockings, and golf shirts. Embroidery is available with a wide variety of thread or yarn color.



Caucasus embroidery

An interesting characteristic of embroidery is that the basic techniques or stitches on surviving examples of the earliest embroidery—chain stitch, buttonhole or blanket stitch, running stitch, satin stitch, cross stitch—remain the fundamental techniques of hand embroidery today.

TYPES OF EMBROIDERY

Embroidery has traditionally enhanced a dress. A look at the various types of threadwork...

As far as the world of design is concerned, embroidery is the backbone of Pakistan. It has left an indelible imprint even on international fashion like Escada, Lingara and Ferra have their ensembles embroidered in India and Pakistan. Do we know enough about our own embroideries and how to use them efficiently? The thoughtful use of embroidery can enhance an ensemble, and take it from the mundane to the extraordinary. Some embroideries that can do wonders for an outfit are:

Aabla	<i>Mirror work which has its roots in Rajasthan and Kutch.</i>
Aari	<i>Embroidery done on a cot. Also known as khatla work aari originated in Barabanki.</i>
Badla	<i>Flat metallic wire, silver or gilt wire embroidery.</i>
Butas and Butis	<i>Motifs composed of floral forms fitted into paisley shapes derived from the Mughal era.</i>
Phool Patti Work	<i>Applique work from Aligarh where usually organdi or other fabric cutouts in floral and leaf motifs are affixed on to a plain fabric sometimes in tandem with silver tilla embroidery.</i>
Chikan Work	<i>Originating from Lucknow this involves a technique of finding separated warp and weft threads for a textural effect.</i>
Taipchi	<i>Darn stitch on muslin.</i>
Khatwa	<i>Inverted satin stitch on muslin.</i>
Murri or Phanda	<i>Satin stitch knots.</i>
Jaali	<i>Network.</i>
Phulkari	<i>Flower motifs, geometric patterns, surface satin stitching using silk floss threads. Phulkari has its origin in Punjab.</i>
Zardosi	<i>Leaf-scroll worked in gold and silver thread on silk, satin, velvet and other rich fabrics.</i>

Zardosi is also combined with Dabka work and is originally from Lucknow.

Mokaish *Silver dots strewn all over is Mokaish work.*

Kashida *Mix of textile embroidery and printing.*

Ek taar *Single thread embroidery used in tandem with crystals.*

Resham *Fine silk thread-work.*

Bead and Crystal Work *Resham work is teamed with beads, baggets, diamantes, rhinestones and Swarovski crystal.*

Sitara Work *Sequins are embroidered into the fabric.*

Embroidery has been an integral part of Pakistani culture and its cottage industry. Reflections of ancient, Muslim and modern culture can be found in Pakistani embroidery. This very nature of Pakistani embroidery has enabled it to endure down to the current era. Despite the advent of machine based embroidery, the traditional hand embroidery of Pakistan remains as popular as ever.

Multani embroidery

Multan has long been an important center of Pakistani embroidered art. Locally known as, it involves creating simple as well as intricate patterns ranging from floral motifs to paisley designs in bright colors. Multani embroidery is typically visible on shawls, cushions, and traditional shalwar kameez suits. More recently, Multani embroidery has taken on simpler motifs on kurtas, popular among young, modern consumers.

For glamorous clothing options such as **bridal wear, sitara work and beadwork** is very popular. Sitara work involves creating patterns by arranging sequins on fabric. People use sitara work to create floral, as well as geometric patterns. Simpler and understated designs are also preferred elegant eveningwear. Because of the popularity of sitara work abroad, this kind of embroidery has also found its way into home furnishings. Table runners, curtains, and cushions regularly have designs of sitara embroidery, which add a touch of glamour to the house.

Beadwork creates simple and artistic designs on daily clothing and formal wear. It adds a touch of elegance and humility to the garment. Designers usually arrange the beads around the hem and borders, and sew them in place by hand. Beadwork is also ideal to create motifs on long tunics and bridal wear. Its popularity has encouraged designers to use beadwork to decorate footwear, bags, purses, and wall hangings for the home. Of late, beadwork on artificial as well as gold jewelry has also become popular.

Zari embroidery is also very popular in Pakistan, although slightly more expensive. Zari embroidery involves the use of gold or silver thread to create patterns on brocade or the borders of saris and long skirts. Nowadays, designers prefer using polyester thread with gold color instead. Mirror work is also popular with small rounded mirrors sewn in patterns on traditional clothing as well as a number of home furnishing items such as cushions, wall hangings and bed linen.

Pashtun embroidery is very beautiful . Embroidery is used by Pashtuns to decorate a wide range of objects. It is used for household objects such as table cloths, mats, towels, curtains, bags, prayer cloths, as well as decorative blankets for horses and camels. "There are various groups of Pashtun, each with their own style of embroidery. There is also a difference between Pashtun urban embroidery and Pashtun nomadic embroidery.

The Pashtun living in the Wardak region, for example, are noted for multi-coloured silk embroideries on a monochrome cotton or silk ground. The embroideries are worked in satin stitch in complex geometric designs that radiate out from a central motif, such as a star.

Khamak,

an intricate form of embroidery, is worked in silk thread and is a trademark of Kandahar. Girls learn this ancient art form at an early age and continue to do it throughout their lives. Inspired by complex Islamic geometric patterns, Khamak is unique to Kandahar and is considered by art experts to be one of the world's finest embroidery techniques. It is traditionally used to decorate the striking, floor-length shawls worn by Southern Afghan men, as well as table linen, women's head-coverings, and girls' wedding trousseaus.

Phulkari, a traditional embroidery art, is well known for its intricate designs and bright cheerful colours worn by Punjabi women on special occasions and ceremonies. The word 'Phulkāri' is made of two words Phul and Kāri, where Phul means flower and Kāri means technique, denoting the technique of making flowers with needle and thread. Some scholars feel that the art of Phulkāri came from Iran where it is known as Gulkāri. There are references to phulkāri in Vedas, Mahabharat, Guru Granth Sahib and the folk songs of Punjab. In its present form, phulkāri embroidery has been popular since the 15th century AD, but the art probably reached its zenith in the late 19th and early 20th centuries. It is a form of craft in which embroidery is done in a simple and sparse design over shawls and *dupattas*. In some cases where the design is worked over very closely, covering the material entirely so that the base cloth is not visible, it is called *bagh* (a garden of flowers).

Every region of Pakistan offers its unique patterns, motifs, and colors of hand embroidery. Mirror work, used extensively on clothing and headgear among the traditional people of Baluchistan, is also becoming popular in urban areas and abroad.

Embroidery work is done on a large scale in Pakistan. Not only men, but women of Pakistan also do this elegant work on different types of clothing and accessories. Embroidery work has importance in Pakistan as well as in its neighboring country India. So, it must be said that embroidery is the token of traditional work of these two countries. Pakistan possessed many

textile production ideas from the start and also adapted some at the time of Partition. Many craftsmen moved from the neighbor country to Pakistan. Not only this, but Pakistan also adapted some of the embroidery techniques from Afghanistan, Iran and China so it must be said that most of the Pakistani embroidery techniques are a mixture of these four countries. Many types of embroidery techniques are used to create beautiful pieces of this artwork. Pakistan produces elegant sheesha work pieces which have their own importance in Pakistani needlework traditions. Pakistani embroidery work is also considered important internationally and they can be bought online from any popular website. Moreover, you can find many types of embroidery work pieces locally as well. The most common embroidery types are Mokaish which can be made by strewing silver dots on a piece of cloth, Jaali work which is done by making a network of strings, Resham, which is thread work done with fine silk and sitara work in which sequins are attached to the cloth.

The style of embroidery work varies with each region of Pakistan. Every region produces its own distinctive pieces of this artwork. If one looks at the history of this embroidery work of Pakistan, then he will get to know that this artwork was famous among all the ancient tribal groups and so each style is adapted by each tribal group. Nowadays, dresses are decorated all over with different types of crystals and sequins.

Embroidery work is a great skill, which is appreciated by all the parents and they make their children learn this beautiful artwork. Moreover, it is also taught in different institutes of Pakistan to make the students aware of its cultural importance. This artwork done with hand is more expensive than those designs which are made with machine.